CURTIN EXECUTIVE EDUCATION · FIELD GUIDE

The Human Edge

Using and delivering AI with judgement

Four reusable decision tools for using AI with judgement. Everyone has the same tools now. What you add is knowing what to ask, when to trust the answer, and where a person stays in charge.

01 TRUST TOOL

02 RTCF

03 CHECK LOOP

04 OPPORTUNITY FINDER

Direct it. Don't delegate. Never surrender.

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THE GUIDE ON ONE PAGE

Same tools. Different judgement.

Large language models, the generative AI behind chat assistants, predict the most plausible answer. What comes back is a convincing average: fluent, well-shaped and usually about right. Most of the time that is useful. Sometimes you need the exact answer, and the average is a guess that looks like one.

The hard part is that AI's mistakes don't look like mistakes. A rushed human draft shows its gaps. AI's wrong work arrives polished and confident, so the instinct you rely on to spot weak work stays quiet. The four tools in this guide replace that instinct with a short, repeatable check. They work on any AI product, and they don't expire when the next model ships. They also apply beyond chat: a fraud score, a demand forecast or any other machine-learning output can be placed on the trust tool and checked the same way.

EXHIBIT 1 · FOUR TOOLS, ONE PER QUESTION

01 · TRUST TOOL

How much should I trust this output?

Two questions place any output in one of four corners. The corner sets the check.

02 · RTCF

How do I ask for what I need?

Role, Task, Context, Format. Plus four upgrades when the output is still weak.

03 · CHECK LOOP

How do I know it's right?

Frame, explore, verify, shape. Verification comes from outside the tool.

04 · OPPORTUNITY FINDER

Where does it fit? Will it work weekly?

Spot the signals, decide who leads each step, then deliver it with checkpoints and a 30-day gate.

Each tool answers one question. Use them in any order; the trust tool runs underneath all of them.

How the tools fit together

WHEN YOU...	USE	THE MOVE
Look for where AI could help	Opportunity Finder	Spot a recurring task, decide who leads each step, start with a quick win.
Are about to type a prompt	RTCF	Brief it like a capable new colleague. Context does most of the work.
Get an output back	Trust tool	How exact must it be? What if it's wrong? The corner tells you how hard to check.
Work with data or facts	Check loop	Frame the question, explore, verify from outside, then say what you checked.
Put AI into a real workflow	Opportunity Finder · Deliver	Design the human checkpoints in, tell the people affected, and set a scale, pivot or kill gate.

> **Three principles run through all four.** There are no magic words, only good briefs. The tool can't reliably check its own work, so the check comes from outside it. And your name goes on the output, not the tool's.

TOOL 1

01 The trust tool

How much should I trust this output?

Ask two questions about any output before you act on it. The answers place it in one of four corners, and the corner tells you how much checking it needs.

Question 1 · How exact must it be?

Average: the ballpark is fine. A draft, a summary, ideas to react to.
Precise: there is one right answer and close is the same as wrong. A figure, a name, a date, a citation, a clause.

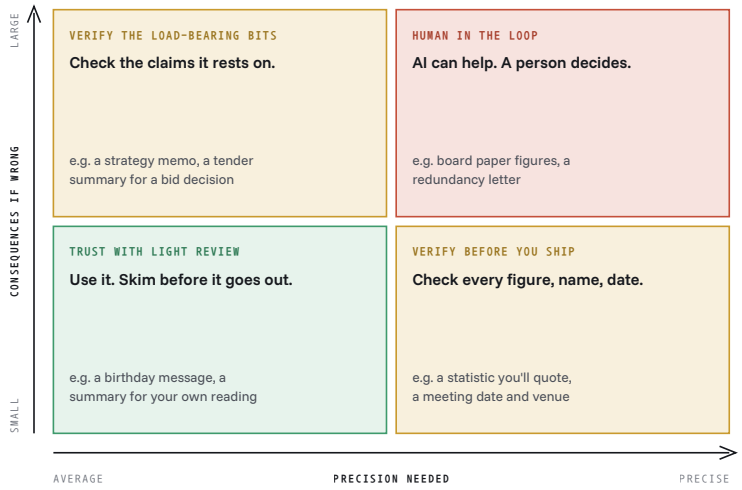
Question 2 · What happens if it's wrong?

Small: cheap to fix, easy to reverse, nobody harmed.
Large: money, safety, reputation, someone's job or wellbeing.

Rule of thumb

Lean in where about-right on low stakes is fine. Keep a person in charge where exactly-right meets high stakes. Most AI failures in the news are red-corner outputs treated as green ones.

EXHIBIT 2 · THE TRUST TOOL



Same layout and corner names as the practice game at trusttool.borck.education.

Check from outside the tool. Asking the AI "are you sure?" doesn't count: it tends to agree with itself. The check comes from the data, the source document, a colleague who knows, or your own arithmetic. That is an old professional skill, not a new AI one.

Better models move the corners. They need less checking on easy ground. They never remove the obligation to place the output first.

Sharp where you know, trusting where you don't. You catch AI's errors in your own field, then believe it on the law, the market or the numbers. Be most sceptical where you know least. (Michael Crichton's "Gell-Mann amnesia", 2002.) The mirror image: "that's just ChatGPT" isn't a critique. Judge the reasoning, not where it came from.

Practise until it's a reflex

The free game at **trusttool.borck.education** has ten scenarios per domain with an explanation on every card. Then place three tasks from your own week. Where you hesitate is usually a question about stakes: who sees this next, and what do they do with it?

TOOL 2

02 RTCF

How do I ask for what I need?

Prompting is briefing, not spell-casting. Write the prompt the way you would brief a smart, fast colleague who is new to your job. Everything they would need to know belongs in the brief.

EXHIBIT 3 · THE FOUR PARTS OF A BRIEF

PART	ASK YOURSELF	EXAMPLE	NOTE
Role	Who should it write as?	A senior HR adviser in a mid-sized Australian firm	Sets tone and vocabulary. The lightest of the four.
Task	What exactly, and how much?	Draft a reply to the client. Under 200 words.	Use a clear verb and a scope: how many, how long.
Context	What does it need to know?	18-month client. Their board shifted priorities. I want a meeting, not a rewrite.	**Does most of the work.** The only part the tool can't guess.
Format	What should it look like?	Email. Acknowledge, explain, propose, close.	Ask for the shape you'll paste, so you don't have to rework it.

Not every prompt needs all four. Anything that matters does.

Before

```
Write an email about the project delay.
```

Generic, polite, and unusable without a rewrite.

After

```
ROLE     Senior project manager. Plain-spoken and warm.
TASK     Write to the client about a two-week delivery delay.
CONTEXT  A vendor's API integration ran late. The client values
         transparency and the relationship is good. New date: 15
March.
FORMAT   Under 200 words. Acknowledge, explain, new date, recommit.
```

What goes in Context

Audience (who reads it and what they care about) · **situation** (what happened, what's at stake) · **constraints** (length, Australian English, policy) · **prior work** (paste the notes, the data, the earlier email) · **stakes**: "write this for someone who must decide this week and can't undo it" sharpens everything after it.

When the output is still weak: four upgrades

Add one upgrade before you rewrite from scratch. They help smaller, older and free-tier models the most, which matters if your workplace has approved a cheaper model. The best models still do better with them.

UPGRADE	WHAT IT DOES	LINE TO ADD
+ Example	Shows instead of describing. The strongest single upgrade.	`Match the length and tone of this example: [paste]`
+ Done	Defines success, and gives permission to be unsure.	`Done means under 200 words, figures only from my notes, and anything you're unsure of marked [CHECK].`
+ Questions	Surfaces the context you forgot to give.	`Before you start, ask me up to five questions.`
+ Steps	Stops the model losing the thread on long jobs.	`Give me an outline only. We'll draft one section at a time.`

Push back: three ways

Models are tuned to please. Disagree with no evidence and many will fold. You decide what survives.

MOVE	USE IT TO	LINE TO ADD
Guardrail	Keep it honest	`Only change your assessment if I give you a new fact. Name the fact that changed it.`
Devil's advocate	Make it attack	`Don't flatter me. Give me three reasons this fails, and name the assumption it all rests on.`
Board of directors	Hear a room, not a voice	`Respond as a board: a CFO, a sceptical customer and a frontline manager. One paragraph each, then where they disagree.`

Long chats drift. After many exchanges a model absorbs your framing and stops challenging it. For an independent read, start a fresh chat.

Five common mistakes

MISTAKE	WHAT HAPPENS	FIX
Too vague	''Help me with this report.'' Nothing to work with.	Add a verb and a scope: summarise into five points for the board.
No context	Generic output you'll rewrite anyway.	Audience, situation, constraints, and the material itself.
No format	A wall of text you can't paste.	Name the shape: table, email, headings, word limit.
Too much at once	A full business case, shallow everywhere.	One section per prompt (the Steps upgrade).
Accepting the first draft	Settling for close enough.	Treat it as a draft: ''shorter'', ''more on X'', ''less formal''.

Save what works

A prompt you'll reuse is an asset. Save it with four things: a **name**, **when to use it**, the **prompt** with [blanks] for what changes, and the **check** it needs (its trust-tool corner). A saved prompt with its check attached is the first draft of what agent tools call a skill.

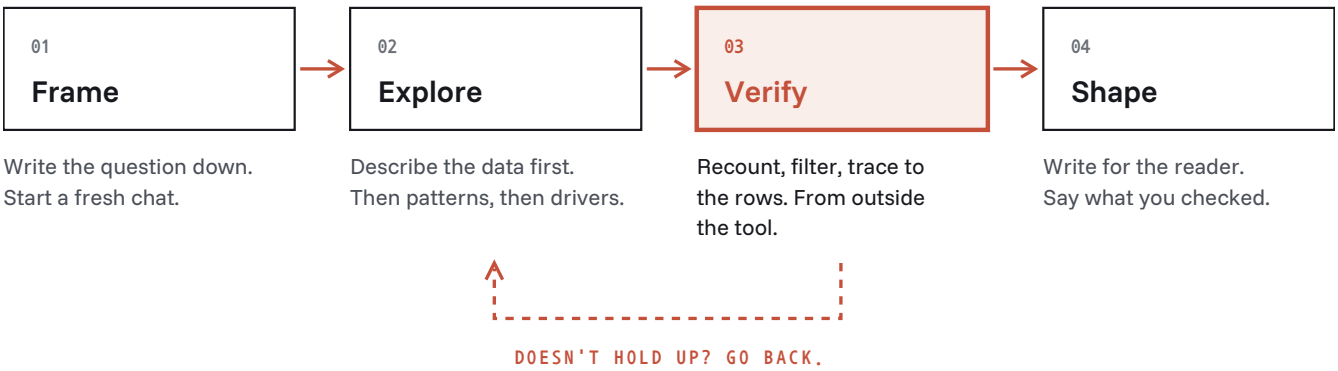
TOOL 3

03 The check loop

How do I know it's right?

AI makes analysis fast. It doesn't make it trustworthy. The most dangerous output is a plausible, professional claim that is simply wrong. The check loop has four steps, and most of the value is in the third.

EXHIBIT 4 · THE CHECK LOOP



01 Frame

Write the question and the decision it feeds before you open the tool. Start a fresh chat so earlier conversation doesn't steer the analysis.

02 Explore

Ask it to describe the data first: rows, columns, dates. Does that match what you know? Then go broad to deep.

03 Verify

If a number would change a decision, check it yourself: filter, recount, open the source. If it doesn't hold, go back.

04 Shape

Write for the reader. End with one line on what you checked and how.

Five ways a smooth answer goes wrong

FAILURE	WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE
Miscounts	Totals that are wrong after filtering or grouping.
Correlation sold as cause	"Sunday tickets are slower, so Sundays cause complaints."
Silent gaps	Missing or messy rows skipped without saying so.
Numbers that can't all be true	Shares that add to 112%. An average above the maximum.
Invented detail	A data point, quote or source that isn't in the file.

VET claims you can't check against your own data. Verify the source yourself. **Explain** it back in your own words. **Test** the edges: when would it be wrong?

TOOL 4

04 The Opportunity Finder

Where does it fit, and will it work every week?

Three steps: spot the signals in your recurring work, decide who leads each step, then start with the quick wins.

1 · Spot: four signals

SIGNAL	YOU NOTICE THAT...	TYPICAL TASKS
Automate	You do it often, the same way.	Status reports, sorting requests, reformatting, data entry from forms.
Assist	You read, gather and compare.	Vendor proposals, meeting prep, long documents, staying current.
Generate	You write from a blank page.	Client emails, job ads, process documents, first drafts.
Analyse	You hunt for meaning in numbers.	Monthly KPIs, survey comments, budget variance, feedback themes.

2 · Assign: who leads each step

EXHIBIT 5 · THE TASK SPECTRUM

AI LEADS	AI ASSISTS	YOU LEAD	HUMAN ONLY
AI drafts it. You review and approve.	**You steer. AI does much of the work.**	**You do the thinking. AI takes sub-tasks.**	**Empathy, ethics, accountability.**
e.g. minutes from your notes	e.g. a client proposal	e.g. a strategy paper	e.g. telling someone their role is going

The bar shows roughly how much of the work AI does. When in doubt, start with more human involvement and hand over as the AI proves itself.

3 · Prioritise: quick wins first

For each candidate, estimate the time it would save each week and the effort to set up. Count the checking as part of the effort. A task that saves 30 minutes but needs 25 minutes of verification is not a quick win, which is why quick wins usually sit in the trust tool's green corner.

The ten-minute weekly audit. List everything you did last week that took more than 15 minutes. Mark the signal, the time and who should lead. Circle the three with the biggest saving and the cheapest check. Start with one.

EXHIBIT 6 · PRIORITY MATRIX



Why AI projects fail differently

YOU USUALLY ASSUME	WITH AI	SO YOU
"Done" can be specified.	Outputs vary: a spread, not one right answer.	Decide what "good enough" means, up front.
A working demo means nearly there.	The demo is a trap; it shows the happy path.	Treat the demo as the start of the hard part.
The data is a known input.	The data is the uncertainty. You find out by using it.	Plan for discovery, not slippage.
The build is the product.	Checking is the product.	Design the checking in, and ship it.
Capability is our edge.	Everyone has the same models.	Compete on your people's judgement.

Deliver it: design the human in

MOVE	WHAT TO DECIDE BEFORE YOU START
Scope	One workflow, one owner, one success measure. Record today's time and quality as the baseline.
Checkpoints	Every step in an amber or red trust corner gets a named person and a specific check, before the output moves on. Pick someone who knows what right looks like, and keep at least one human step on purpose, to build capability.
People	Who is affected, who has to agree, who will do the checking. Tell them before you start.
Gate	A date (30 days works) and the criteria that would make you scale, pivot or kill it. Decide now, before you're invested.

Worked example: the weekly team update (a fuller version of the Exercise 7 example)

STEP	BEFORE	WHO LEADS	CHECKPOINT	AFTER
Gather updates from the team	15 min	You lead	-	15 min
Consolidate into the template	15 min	AI leads	A me, a light read	3 min
Write the summary paragraph	10 min	AI leads	A me, a light read	4 min
Calculate the project metrics	15 min	You lead	C me, recount totals	15 min
Send to the sponsor	5 min	Human only	-	5 min
Total	**60 min**			**42 min**

Gate, day 30: scale if the summary needs two edits or fewer each week; pivot (add an example to the brief) if it needs more; kill if the sponsor ever spots an error in it.

AT THE GATE	WHEN	THEN
SCALE	It met the measure with a light review.	Hand it over for good. Keep the check its corner calls for.
PIVOT	Close, but the checking costs too much.	Change the brief, the step, or who leads. Run another month.
KILL	It missed, or the errors mattered.	Keep it human. Revisit next quarter: the tools will have moved.

Killing is a good outcome: you found the line cheaply. Avoid sunk cost, cherry-picking the measures that passed, and treating "not perfect" as "broken".

SAFEGUARDS

Three rules before you paste.

1 · Classify it, then pick the tool

Public, internal, confidential or regulated? Internal and above only into approved tools. The risk is the pipeline (where data goes, who keeps it), as with email. Never paste passwords or keys.

2 · Leave out what identifies people

Names, health details, client data, anything under NDA. If you can't share it, describe its shape instead of pasting it.

3 · Know what it remembers

Assistants keep memories separately from your chat history. See the table below, and use a temporary chat for anything sensitive.

What your assistant remembers

Most assistants now learn across sessions. That knowledge sits in three separate stores, and you manage each one separately.

STORE	WHAT IT IS	HOW TO MANAGE IT
What you told it	Facts you asked it to keep ("remember that I prefer...").	Review and delete in the memory or personalisation settings.
What it inferred	Patterns drawn from your chats. Why an assistant can start to feel too personal.	A separate setting. **Deleting chats may not delete this.**
The chats	The conversation history you can see.	Delete one at a time or in bulk in privacy or data settings.

Use a temporary chat for anything you don't want learned. And never send AI output you haven't read: your name goes on it.

Find the quiet defaults

Bias now hides in small choices. Ask for a scene with "a respected senior manager", then "a respected administrative officer", and compare who gets a title, who is warm and who holds authority. Those defaults leak into AI-drafted references and reviews.

Agents, harnesses and skills

Agent

A model in a loop with tools. It plans, acts, checks and tries again until the job is done. AI is moving from a tool you visit to a capability inside the software you already use.

Harness

The software around the model: its standing instructions, what it can read, the tools it may call, and the model it runs on. A chat window is a harness. So is Copilot in Outlook.

Skill

A plain-text brief the harness loads when your request matches it. Your saved RTCF prompt, its format and its check are exactly what goes in one. Because it's text, it moves between tools.

An agent automates the loop, not the standard. A loop that checks its own work shares the model's blind spots. Whatever an agent produces still needs a check from outside: your test, your data, your reviewer.

KEEP PRACTISING

Delegate the task. Keep the learning.

Routine work used to teach you while you did it: reading the documents taught you what matters, drafting taught you what good looks like, checking numbers taught you where errors hide. When AI does that work, the practice doesn't come with the job any more. You have to choose it.

THE EVIDENCE: FEWER JUNIOR HIRES, NOT MASS REPLACEMENT

Australia. No broad AI-driven upheaval, and youth outcomes have mostly held up, but the most AI-exposed occupations are growing more slowly (DEWR, July 2026). Some employers now hire more seniors and fewer juniors; one software firm saw "no logical business reason to take on a junior engineer and train them up in situ in the same way" (JSA).

United States. Payroll data show employment of 22 to 25 year olds in AI-exposed jobs about 19% below trend, mostly through fewer hires, with no comparable gap for experienced workers.

DEWR (2026) AI and employment in Australia, Office of the Chief Economist · Jobs and Skills Australia (2025) Our Gen AI Transition: Generative AI Capacity Study · Brynjolfsson, Chandar & Chen (rev. 2026) "Canaries in the Coal Mine?", Stanford Digital Economy Lab.

The two-pass habit

Pick one task that matters. Do a rough pass yourself first, ten minutes, rough is fine. Then give AI the same task with your best brief, and compare.

Where it beat you is your blind spot, so practise there. **Where you beat it** is its limit, and that's where its output needs your check. Half an hour a week.

The corners move; the check stays. As models improve, more work needs only a light review. The top-right corner never empties.

Your plan

WHEN	MOVE	COMMITMENT
This week	Practise	Two-pass one task that matters. Use one saved prompt for real.
This month	Deliver	Run your delivery plan, with checkpoints in place from day one.
Day 30	Gate	Scale, pivot or kill, against the criteria you set before you started.
This quarter	Revisit	Name what must stay human in your role. Check whether the corners have moved.

If you lead people

Say the reasoning out loud

When you fix someone's work, explain why the standard is the standard. Juniors used to absorb that through repetition.

Run side-by-side drills

By hand first, then with AI, then compare what each one missed.

Choose what stays human

Decide which fundamentals your team keeps practising on purpose. Revisit as the tools improve.

The "broken ladder" framing of the junior pipeline problem draws on Dylan Davis. The trust tool and conversation-not-delegation ideas are developed further in *Conversation, Not Delegation* (michael-borck.github.io/conversation-not-delegation). Choosing which AI initiatives deserve investment is the focus of the companion masterclass, **AI in Strategy: Choosing where to invest**.